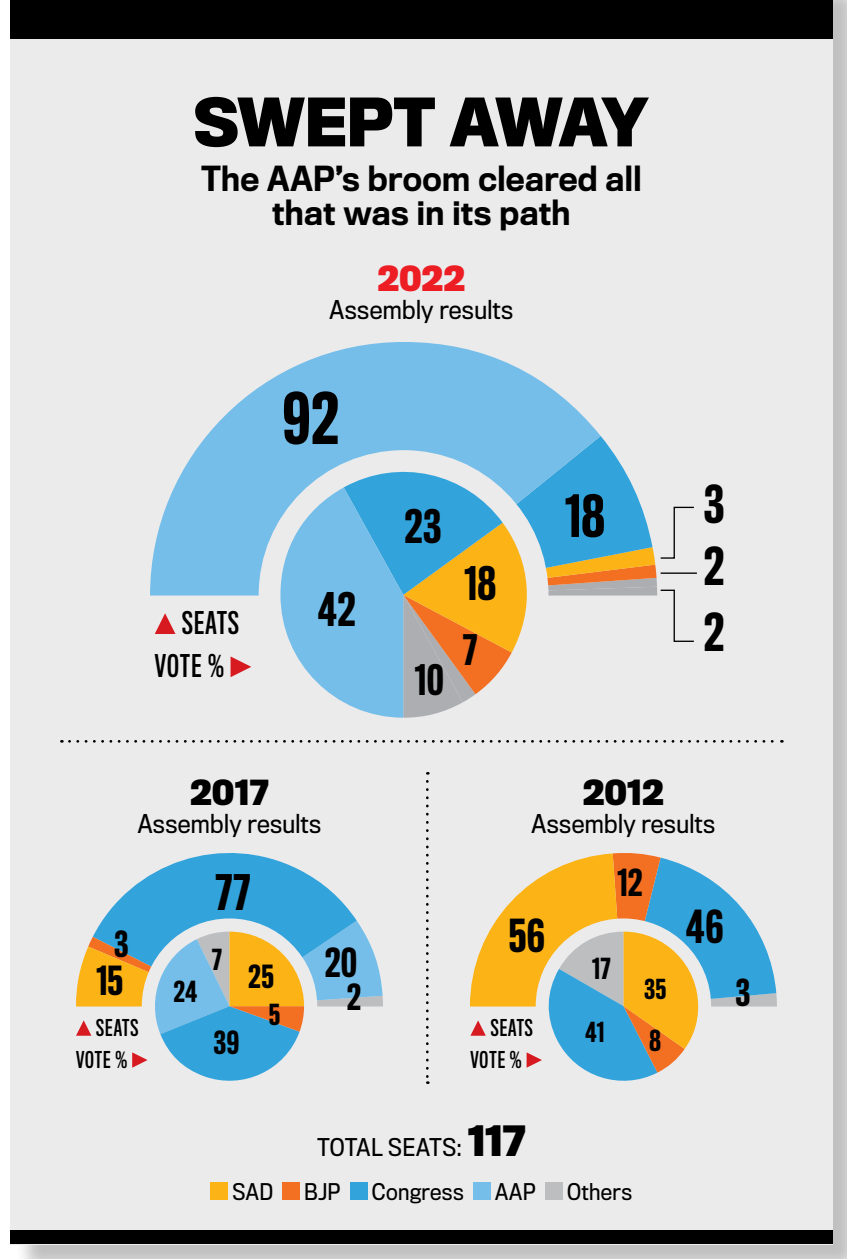


FORGING AHEAD Kejriwal and CM-in-waiting Bhagwant Mann at an election rally in Patiala

Photographs by ANI



WITHIN THE FIRST HOUR of counting in Punjab, the sound of bursting firecrackers and jubilant *dhol*s erupted in the otherwise sleepy town of Dhuri. Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) supporters wielding brooms—the party's election symbol—had reached the residence of Bhagwant Mann, their local candidate and AAP's chief ministerial face. By lunchtime, the celebrations had spread across the state as AAP headed for a historic landslide with 92 seats (42 per cent vote share).

Mann, a popular comedian-turned-politician in the mould of the Italian Beppe Grillo or Ukrainian president Volodymyr Zelensky, has earned quite a cult following with his merciless broadsides against the political establishment. The Sangrur MP since 2014, Mann's wit-laced oratory has created its own niche in the Lok Sabha. And back home, those relentless barbs helped keep voters healthily sceptical of Punjab's two heavyweights, Parkash Singh Badal of the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) and Amarinder Singh (formerly Congress), and their parties. That gave voice to the voters' disenchantment with conventional parties.

This feeling left its mark in the